

I'm bored!

Play Cards

150 screen-free play ideas for ages 1–12, each with what you need, how to play, a talk prompt and a safety note.



150 cards + 36 seasonal

Ages 1–12, sorted by age

Calm • Medium • Wiggly

A talk prompt on every card

Also inside: summer & rainy-day sets • jar labels • box dividers • play menu • weekly planner • editable blanks

Boredom is where play begins.

“I’m bored!” isn’t a problem you have to fix. It’s a pause, and pauses are where children start inventing. These cards give that pause a gentle nudge: one simple idea, the few everyday things you need, and one thing to say while you play.



Talk is built in

Every card ends with a talk prompt. The back-and-forth (your question, their answer, your answer back) is what turns an activity into time together.



Sorted by age and energy

Choose your child’s age band, then ask one question: calm, medium or wiggly? Matching the mood makes a “yes” much more likely.



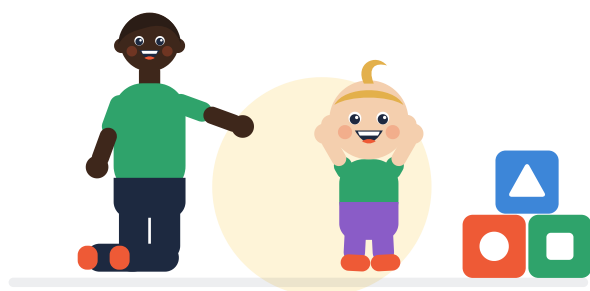
Safety on every card

Each card carries its own safety line, and every card for ages 1–3 uses only things bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Made from everyday things

Pots, socks, boxes, paper, a walk outside. No shopping list, no batteries, no screens.



WHAT’S INSIDE

- 150** play cards in 4 age bands: 1–3, 3–5, 5–8, 8–12
- 36** seasonal cards: 18 summer + 18 rainy-day
- 30** blank “your idea” cards, plus a fillable editable file
- 18** box dividers: ages, kinds of play, favorites
- 10** jar labels in 4 colorways, including energy jars
- 6** card-back designs for double-sided printing
- 1** Today’s Play Menu choice board (velcro-ready)
- 2** Our Play Week planners: Monday or Sunday start

US Letter + A4 · fillable blanks · PNG template set · index & checklist

1

Print

Cardstock, at 100% (actual size).

2

Cut & store

Into a jar, a recipe box or a ring.

3

Pull a card

Or offer a pick of three.

4

Play & talk

Use the talk prompt, then follow their lead.

Your job as the grown-up

You don’t have to entertain. Set out the things on the card, play for the first few minutes, then step back and let your child lead. Say what you see, wait, and answer their answer.

Read a card in five seconds.

1 AGES 3-5 **WIGGLY**

MUSIC & SOUND

Feelings Freeze

4 YOU NEED
Songs to sing or hum

5 TRY IT
Dance. When the song stops, freeze with a feeling face: happy, grumpy, surprised. Guess each other's.

6 TALK
"What made your statue grumpy?"

7 Grown-up nearby. 3-5 · 17

- 1 Age band**
The color tells you the age band at a glance.
- 2 Energy level**
One, two or three bars: calm, medium or wiggly.
- 3 Kind of play**
Eight kinds, each with its own icon and divider.
- 4 You need**
Everyday things only. Gather them first.
- 5 Try it**
One or two short steps. Change anything you like.
- 6 Talk**
One thing to say or ask while you play.
- 7 Safety line**
Read it before you start, every time.

FOUR AGE BANDS



Bands overlap on purpose. Children move between them, so try the band above or below whenever a card fits your child.

THREE ENERGY LEVELS

CALM
Sit-down play for winding down, quiet mornings and before bed.

MEDIUM
Up-and-about play: pretend, building, helping, walks.

WIGGLY
Big-body play for burning energy, indoors or out.

Wiggly cards count toward active play. The World Health Organization's 2019 guidelines recommend at least 180 minutes a day of varied physical activity for children aged 1-4, spread across the day.

EIGHT KINDS OF PLAY

Build & Make

Pretend

Move

Outdoors

Words & Stories

Music & Sound

Kitchen & Helping

Games & Puzzles

What play looks like at each age.

Every child plays differently, and age bands are a starting point, not a rule. Here is what play often looks like in each band, and the easiest way for a grown-up to join in.

AGES 1–3

Do it again!

PLAY LOOKS LIKE

Filling and dumping, stacking and knocking down, copying you, again and again.

YOUR PART

Be the partner on the floor. Keep turns short, and repeat whatever gets a smile.

TALK TIP

Short words and long pauses. Say what they're doing ("In! Out!"), then wait for any sound or gesture back.

THREE TO TRY FIRST

Tower and Crash

Sink Helper

Picture Walk

AGES 3–5

Let's pretend

PLAY LOOKS LIKE

Pretend worlds, chasing games, simple rules, and stories that change every minute.

YOUR PART

Take a part in the story (customer, patient, passenger) and let your child direct.

TALK TIP

Ask "what happens next?" and add one new word to what they say.

THREE TO TRY FIRST

Cushion Fort

Pretend Café

Feelings Freeze

AGES 5–8

Let me try

PLAY LOOKS LIKE

Building, making, games with rules, and inventions of their own.

YOUR PART

Set it up, then step back. Be the tester, the audience or the rule-checker.

TALK TIP

Ask "why?" and "how did you figure that out?", and give them time to answer.

THREE TO TRY FIRST

Paper Plane Contest

Dance Party DJ

One-Word Story

AGES 8–12

My idea!

PLAY LOOKS LIKE

Projects, challenges, strategy, and real skills like cooking, fixing and planning.

YOUR PART

Be the assistant, not the boss. Offer the time and materials, then admire the result.

TALK TIP

Ask for their plan and their opinion, and share yours too.

THREE TO TRY FIRST

Cook from a Recipe

Chain Reaction

Home Escape Room

Safety first, then fun.

Every card has a safety line at the bottom. These are the rules behind them. They apply to every card, including the ones you write yourself.



A grown-up is always in charge

Every card assumes an adult nearby. For ages 1–3, stay within reach the whole time.



Water

Any amount of water means a grown-up within arm's reach, the whole time. Empty tubs and buckets straight after play.



Cords, strings and scarves

Nothing long enough to wrap around a neck: no long strings, cords, ties or long scarves. Sheets and blankets are draped, never tied.



Outdoors

Play well away from the street. No berries or mushrooms. Hats, water and shade in the sun. No puddle play in thunder or lightning.



Small parts and under-3s

For children under 3, use only things too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm across). Every 1–3 card is written this way. Older cards that use small things (coins, dice, tape, seeds) say so: keep those away from younger brothers and sisters.



No balloons

Balloons are not safe for children under 8, so no card in this pack uses them.



Food and the kitchen

Sit down to eat. No whole grapes, nuts, popcorn, hard candy or marshmallows for young children. Check allergies. Grown-ups handle sharp knives, the stove and the oven.



Hide-and-seek

Never hide in appliances, chests, trunks or cars.



Too big to fit: OK



Fits: too small

THE TOILET-PAPER TUBE TEST

If it fits through the tube, it's too small for under-3s.

Keep a cardboard tube in the play basket and test anything new before a toddler plays with it. A tube is about 1.25 in (3.2 cm) across.

The cards themselves

Printed and laminated cards are paper, not toys for children who still mouth things. Round laminated corners, and keep velcro dots, rings and the jar lid out of reach of little ones.

You know your child best

Skip or change any card that doesn't suit your child, your space or your day. These cards are ideas for play at home. They are not medical or developmental advice.

Make them last.

- 1 Print**
Print at 100% or “actual size,” not “fit to page.” Cardstock (65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) makes sturdy cards. Pick the US Letter or A4 file to match your paper.
- 2 Card backs (optional)**
Print a sheet of fronts, put it back in the tray and print one backs page on the other side. Test one sheet first. Or print the double-sided cards file and choose “flip on long edge.”
- 3 Cut**
Cut along the light grey lines with a paper trimmer or scissors. The white border around each card hides small wobbles.
- 4 Laminate**
Laminating pouches (3–5 mil) make cards last for years and wipe clean. Leave a thin sealed edge around each card, then round the corners with a corner punch or scissors so there are no sharp points.
- 5 Velcro**
Stick a hook (scratchy) dot on the back of each card you want to use on the Play Menu, and loop (soft) dots on the board. Store spare dots out of reach: they’re small parts.
- 6 Store**
A big jar with one of the labels, a 3 × 5 in recipe box with the dividers, or a binder ring through a punched corner. Keep rings away from little ones.

PAGE GUIDE · PRINT ONLY WHAT YOU NEED

Start here, card guide, safety	1–6
Ages 1–3 cards	7–11
Ages 3–5 cards	12–16
Ages 5–8 cards	17–21
Ages 8–12 cards	22–26
Summer + rainy-day sets	27–30
Card backs (optional)	31–36
Box dividers	37–39
Jar labels	40–41
Play Menu + weekly planners	42–44
Play Jar Star certificate	45
Card index & checklist	46–48
Quick answers	49

HANDY SUPPLIES

- ★ Cardstock, 65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm
- ★ A paper trimmer or scissors
- ★ Laminator and 3–5 mil pouches (optional)
- ★ Corner rounder (optional)
- ★ Hook-and-loop (velcro) dots (optional)
- ★ A big jar or a 3 × 5 in recipe box

Save ink: the cards print beautifully without backs, and the planners and index work fine in black and white.

SIX WAYS TO PLAY WITH THE CARDS

The jar pull

Your child pulls a card. Don’t like it?
Put it back and pull once more.

Pick one of three

Lay out three cards and let your child choose. Choosing is half the fun.

Energy check

Ask “calm, medium or wiggly?” first, then pull from that energy.

Play Menu

Velcro four cards onto the menu each morning: calm, wiggly, together and free choice.

Big helper

An older child reads a 1–3 card aloud and plays it with a younger one, with a grown-up close by.

Season swap

Add the summer or rainy-day set when the weather turns.

AGES 1-3

WIGGLY

MUSIC & SOUND

Pot-and-Spoon Band

YOU NEED

2 pots, 2 wooden spoons

TRY IT

Turn the pots upside down. Drum loud, then soft, then fast, then slow. Take turns copying each other's beat.

TALK

"Loud or quiet? Your turn!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 01

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

PRETEND

Box Car Ride

YOU NEED

A big cardboard box

TRY IT

Your child sits in the box. Push it slowly around the room and stop at "stations" to wave hello.

TALK

"Where should we go? Ready... go!"

Push slowly; the box stays on the floor. 1-3 · 02

AGES 1-3

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Peekaboo Towel

YOU NEED

A dish towel

TRY IT

Hide your face, then a big toy, then your child's foot under the towel. Pause before every "boo!"

TALK

"Where's your foot? There it is!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 03

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Tower and Crash

YOU NEED

Big blocks or empty cereal boxes

TRY IT

Stack them up together and count "one, two, three." Then your child knocks it down. Again!

TALK

"Up, up, up... crash!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 04

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

MOVE

Roll It Back

YOU NEED

A large soft ball

TRY IT

Sit facing each other with legs apart. Roll the ball back and forth. Then roll it under a chair "tunnel."

TALK

"Ready, set... roll!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 05

AGES 1-3

CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Sink Helper

YOU NEED

A tub of shallow water, plastic cups, a towel

TRY IT

Set the tub on a towel on the floor. Fill, pour and "wash" the cups together.

TALK

"Full or empty? Pour it out!"

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. 1-3 · 06

AGES 1-3

CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Sock Match

YOU NEED

A basket of clean grown-up socks

TRY IT

Pull out one sock at a time. Find its partner together and toss each pair in the basket.

TALK

"Same? Not the same?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 07

AGES 1-3

WIGGLY

MOVE

Animal Parade

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Stomp like an elephant, hop like a bunny, waddle like a duck. Follow the leader, then swap.

TALK

"What does the duck say?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 08

AGES 1-3

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Mirror Faces

YOU NEED

Just your faces

TRY IT

Sit face to face. Make a happy, sleepy or surprised face. Your child copies you, then you copy them.

TALK

"You look surprised! Oh!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 09

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

PRETEND

Basket Boat

YOU NEED

A laundry basket, pillows

TRY IT

Your child sits in the basket “boat.” Rock it gently and sing a boat song. Pillows are islands.

TALK

“Row, row... what comes next?”

Basket stays on the floor; stay right beside it.

1-3 · 10

AGES 1-3

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Treasure Box

YOU NEED

A box, 5 big safe things (cup, sock, big spoon)

TRY IT

Put the things in a box. Your child pulls one out. Name it together and show what it does.

TALK

“What’s this? A cup! We drink!”

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-3 · 11

AGES 1-3

WIGGLY

MOVE

Pillow Mountain

YOU NEED

Couch cushions and pillows

TRY IT

Pile cushions low on the floor. Climb up, roll down and crawl through.

TALK

“Up the mountain... and down!”

Keep it low and soft, away from furniture corners.

1-3 · 12

AGES 1-3

WIGGLY

OUTDOORS

Bubble Chase

YOU NEED

Bubbles

TRY IT

Blow bubbles outside. Your child chases and pops them. Wait a moment before you blow the next ones.

TALK

“More bubbles? Say ‘more!’”

Grown-up holds the bubble liquid.

1-3 · 13

AGES 1-3

CALM

PRETEND

Sock Puppet Hello

YOU NEED

A clean sock

TRY IT

Put the sock on your hand. The puppet says hi, sneezes and gets sleepy. Your child feeds it pretend food.

TALK

“Puppet is hungry! What should he eat?”

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-3 · 14

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Color Hunt

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Pick a color. Walk around the house and touch everything that color. Then pick a new one.

TALK

“Red! Where’s more red?”

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-3 · 15

AGES 1-3

WIGGLY

MUSIC & SOUND

Stop-and-Go Dance

YOU NEED

A song you can sing

TRY IT

Sing and dance together. Stop singing and freeze like statues. Start again!

TALK

“Stop! ... Go!”

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-3 · 16

AGES 1-3

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Picture Walk

YOU NEED

A favorite picture book

TRY IT

Skip the words. Point to the pictures and say what you see. Wait for your child to point too.

TALK

“I see a dog. What do you see?”

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-3 · 17

AGES 1-3

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Cups and Bowls

YOU NEED

Nesting bowls or plastic tubs, a big toy

TRY IT

Nest them, stack them, then hide the toy under one and slide them around slowly.

TALK

“Which one? Under here?”

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-3 · 18

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Paint with Water

YOU NEED

A paintbrush, a cup of water

TRY IT

Paint the fence, steps or sidewalk with plain water. Watch the pictures disappear.

TALK

"Where did it go? Paint it again!"

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. 1-3 · 19

AGES 1-3

CALM

PRETEND

Teddy Picnic

YOU NEED

Soft toys, a blanket, plastic cups and plates

TRY IT

Spread the blanket and set a place for each toy. Pretend to pour, share and say "yum."

TALK

"Teddy wants more. More tea?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 20

AGES 1-3

WIGGLY

MOVE

Sheet Tunnel

YOU NEED

A sheet, 2 chairs

TRY IT

Drape the sheet over the chairs to make a tunnel. Crawl through and peek out the end.

TALK

"Where are you? Peekaboo!"

Drape the sheet loose; never tie it. Stay close. 1-3 · 21

AGES 1-3

CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Wipe the Table

YOU NEED

A damp cloth

TRY IT

After a meal, give your child a cloth. Wipe in circles, then back and forth. Sing while you wipe.

TALK

"Wipe, wipe... all clean!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 22

AGES 1-3

CALM

OUTDOORS

Nature Basket

YOU NEED

A basket, a walk

TRY IT

Collect big things: large leaves, big pinecones, short sticks. Sort them at home.

TALK

"Big leaf! Crunchy leaf!"

Only items bigger than a toilet-paper tube. No berries or mushrooms. 1-3 · 23

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Car Ramp

YOU NEED

A couch cushion, a big toy car

TRY IT

Lean a cushion on the couch to make a ramp. Roll the car down. Make the ramp steeper.

TALK

"Ready, set... go!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 24

AGES 1-3

CALM

PRETEND

Pretend Phone Call

YOU NEED

A block or a banana as the "phone"

TRY IT

Pretend to call Grandma. Say hi, wait, then answer. Hand the "phone" to your child.

TALK

"Hello? Who is it?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 25

AGES 1-3

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Big Paper Scribble

YOU NEED

A big sheet of paper, chunky crayons

TRY IT

Draw together: zig-zags, round and round, dot-dot-dot. Name what you make.

TALK

"Round and round... a ball!"

Chunky crayons only; grown-up puts them away after. 1-3 · 26

AGES 1-3

WIGGLY

MOVE

Pillow Hop

YOU NEED

3-4 flat pillows

TRY IT

Lay the pillows in a line on a rug. Step or jump from one to the next like stepping stones.

TALK

"Jump! One more?"

On a rug, away from sharp corners. 1-3 · 27

AGES 1-3 MEDIUM

MUSIC & SOUND

Fill-In Songs

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Sing a song with actions you both know. Stop before a word and wait for your child to fill it in.

TALK

"The wheels on the bus go...?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 28

AGES 1-3 CALM

MUSIC & SOUND

What's That Sound?

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Sit very still and listen. A car? A bird? The fridge? Point to where each sound comes from.

TALK

"Shh... what's that sound?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 29

AGES 1-3 MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Point-and-Name Walk

YOU NEED

A walk outside

TRY IT

Walk slowly. Stop at anything your child looks at and name it: dog, truck, flower.

TALK

"You see the truck! Big truck."

Hold hands near roads and driveways. 1-3 · 30

AGES 1-3 CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Lid Match

YOU NEED

3 light pots or tubs with lids

TRY IT

Take all the lids off. Your child finds which lid fits which pot.

TALK

"Does it fit? Try another!"

Light pots only, far from the stove. 1-3 · 31

AGES 1-3 CALM

PRETEND

Teddy Bedtime

YOU NEED

A soft toy, a small towel

TRY IT

Put teddy to bed: bath, brush teeth, story, song. Let your child lead every step.

TALK

"What does teddy need now?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 32

AGES 1-3 WIGGLY

MOVE

Delivery Push

YOU NEED

A laundry basket, soft toys

TRY IT

Your child pushes the basket across the room to deliver soft toys to each person.

TALK

"Push, push... a delivery for you!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 33

AGES 1-3 MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Where's Teddy?

YOU NEED

A big soft toy

TRY IT

Hide teddy half in view while your child watches. Next time, hide him a little more. Cheer every find.

TALK

"Is he under the chair?"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 34

AGES 1-3 MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Tidy-Up Toss

YOU NEED

A basket, soft toys

TRY IT

Sing a tidy song and toss soft toys into the basket. Count them as they go in.

TALK

"One, two... in it goes!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 35

AGES 1-3 CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Hand Shadows

YOU NEED

A flashlight (grown-up holds it)

TRY IT

In a dim room, make shadow shapes on the wall: a bird, a dog. Help your child make one.

TALK

"Look, a bird! Flap, flap!"

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. 1-3 · 36

AGES 1-3

MEDIUM

MUSIC & SOUND

Knee Bounce Ride

YOU NEED

Your lap

TRY IT

Bounce your child gently on your knees to a rhyme: slow, then bumpy, then a gentle “whoops!”

TALK

“Again? Say ‘again!’”

Gentle bounces; hold your child securely.

1-3 · 37

AGES 1-3

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Fill and Dump

YOU NEED

A big bowl, big blocks or rolled-up socks

TRY IT

Fill the bowl, dump it out, fill it again. Count as things go in.

TALK

“In... in... out!”

Grown-up within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-3 · 38

AGES 1-3

☐ CALM ☐ MED ☐ WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you

Your card play.

AGES 1-3

☐ CALM ☐ MED ☐ WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you

Your card play.

AGES 1-3

☐ CALM ☐ MED ☐ WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you

Your card play.

AGES 1-3

☐ CALM ☐ MED ☐ WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you

Your card play.

AGES 1-3

☐ CALM ☐ MED ☐ WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you

Your card play.

AGES 1-3

☐ CALM ☐ MED ☐ WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you

Your card play.

AGES 1-3

☐ CALM ☐ MED ☐ WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you

Your card play.

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Cushion Fort

YOU NEED

Cushions, a sheet, chairs, books

TRY IT

Build a fort together. Add a door, a sign and a pile of books inside.

TALK

“Who’s allowed in? What’s the password?”



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 • 01

AGES 3-5

WIGGLY

MOVE

The Floor Is Lava

YOU NEED

Pillows, a rug

TRY IT

Scatter pillows on the floor. Cross the room without touching the “lava.”

TALK

“Which pillow is safest? Why?”

Soft floor only; move sharp-cornered furniture. 3-5 • 02

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

PRETEND

Pretend Café

YOU NEED

Plastic dishes, paper, crayons

TRY IT

Your child runs a café. Draw a picture menu. You order; they cook and serve.

TALK

“What do you recommend today?”



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 • 03

AGES 3-5

CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Laundry Sort

YOU NEED

A basket of clean clothes

TRY IT

Sort clothes by color, then by who owns them. Fold washcloths together.

TALK

“Whose sock is this? How do you know?”



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 • 04

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Picture-Clue Hunt

YOU NEED

A toy “treasure,” paper, crayon

TRY IT

Draw 3-5 picture clues (the bed, the fridge). Each clue leads to the next. Treasure at the end!

TALK

“Where does this picture tell us to go?”



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 • 05

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Tape Road

YOU NEED

Painter’s tape, toy cars

TRY IT

Tape a road on the floor with turns, a bridge and a parking lot. Drive the cars along it.

TALK

“Where is your car going next?”

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

3-5 • 06

AGES 3-5

WIGGLY

GAMES & PUZZLES

Simon Says

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Play Simon Says with big moves: touch your toes, spin, hop. Then your child is Simon.

TALK

“Simon says... what should we do?”



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 • 07

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Feel-It Hunt

YOU NEED

A bag, a walk

TRY IT

Find something smooth, something bumpy, something green and something that smells nice.

TALK

“How does it feel? What is it like?”

Look, don’t eat: no berries or mushrooms.

3-5 • 08

AGES 3-5

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Story in a Bag

YOU NEED

A bag, 4 household things

TRY IT

Pull out one thing at a time and add it to a story together. “Once upon a time, a spoon...”

TALK

“And then what happened?”



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 • 09

AGES 3-5 CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Dough Bakery

YOU NEED

Play dough, cookie cutters, a rolling pin

TRY IT

Roll, cut and “bake” dough cookies. Set up a counter and sell them.

TALK

“How many cookies? Which shape?”

Keep dough away from children under 3.

3-5 · 10

AGES 3-5 WIGGLY

GAMES & PUZZLES

Animal Charades

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Take turns acting out an animal without sounds. Guess it. Then add the sound.

TALK

“What clues did you see?”

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 11

AGES 3-5 CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Rhyme Basket

YOU NEED

Things around the house

TRY IT

Find things that rhyme: sock-clock, cat-hat, spoon-moon. Silly made-up words count!

TALK

“What rhymes with ‘bed’?”

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 12

AGES 3-5 CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Veggie Scrub

YOU NEED

A bowl of water, a brush, potatoes or carrots

TRY IT

Scrub the veggies clean. Count them, then line them up from biggest to smallest.

TALK

“Which is the biggest? The muddiest?”

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.

3-5 · 13

AGES 3-5 WIGGLY

MOVE

Obstacle Course

YOU NEED

Pillows, a chair, a blanket

TRY IT

Build a course: crawl under, step over, hop around, touch the wall, run back.

TALK

“What should we add? First... then...”

Clear the space; keep it low.

3-5 · 14

AGES 3-5 CALM

PRETEND

Toy Vet

YOU NEED

Soft toys, strips of cloth

TRY IT

Your child is the vet. Toys come in with an “ouchie.” Check, wrap and give a hug.

TALK

“What happened to Bunny? How can we help?”

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 15

AGES 3-5 CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Sink or Float

YOU NEED

A tub of water, a spoon, a sponge, an apple, a lid

TRY IT

Guess first, then drop each thing in. Sort them into “sink” and “float.”

TALK

“What do you think will happen? Why?”

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.

3-5 · 16

AGES 3-5 WIGGLY

MUSIC & SOUND

Feelings Freeze

YOU NEED

Songs to sing or hum

TRY IT

Dance. When the song stops, freeze with a feeling face: happy, grumpy, surprised. Guess each other's.

TALK

“What made your statue grumpy?”

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 17

AGES 3-5 MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Book Bridge

YOU NEED

Blocks, books, a toy car

TRY IT

Build a bridge between two piles of books. Test it with a car. Can it hold two?

TALK

“What makes it strong?”

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 18

AGES 3-5

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

I Spy Colors

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Say "I spy something... blue!" Take turns. Then try shapes: "something round."

TALK

"Is it big or small? Give me a clue."

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 19

AGES 3-5

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Paper-Plate Masks

YOU NEED

Paper plates, crayons

TRY IT

A grown-up cuts eye holes. Your child colors a lion, a cat or a hero. Hold it up and act it out.

TALK

"Who are you? What can you do?"

Grown-up cuts. Hold masks by hand; 3-5 · 20 no strings.

AGES 3-5

WIGGLY

OUTDOORS

Chalk Hop Path

YOU NEED

Sidewalk chalk

TRY IT

Draw a path of squares, circles and spirals. Hop, jump and spin through it.

TALK

"Which square is trickiest?"

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street. 3-5 · 21

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

WORDS & STORIES

Couch Puppet Show

YOU NEED

Socks or paper bags, a couch

TRY IT

Make two puppets. Put on a show from behind the couch. The grown-up is the audience.

TALK

"What's the problem in your show?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 22

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

PRETEND

Corner Shop

YOU NEED

Food boxes from the cupboard, a bag

TRY IT

Set up a shop. Your child is the shopkeeper. Draw paper money to pay.

TALK

"How much is that? Do you have apples?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 23

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

PRETEND

Mail Carrier

YOU NEED

Folded paper, crayons, a bag

TRY IT

Draw pictures and "mail" them to people and toys around the house. Knock and deliver.

TALK

"Who is this for? What does it say?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 24

AGES 3-5

CALM

OUTDOORS

Bug Watch

YOU NEED

A magnifying glass if you have one

TRY IT

Gently lift leaves with a grown-up. Watch bugs, count their legs, then leave them be.

TALK

"Where is it going? How many legs?"

Look, don't touch. Wash hands after. 3-5 · 25

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

MUSIC & SOUND

Kitchen Band

YOU NEED

Pots, a whisk, a sealed plastic shaker

TRY IT

Make a band from kitchen things. One plays fast, one plays slow. Swap instruments.

TALK

"Which one sounds like rain?"

Keep small pieces away from children under 3. 3-5 · 26

AGES 3-5

CALM

OUTDOORS

Listening Walk

YOU NEED

A walk, paper, crayons

TRY IT

Go outside and count the sounds you hear: birds, cars, wind. Draw them at home.

TALK

"Which sound was the loudest?"

Hold hands near roads.

3-5 · 27

AGES 3-5 MEDIUM

WORDS & STORIES

Opposites Game

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Act out one side of an opposite: big, fast, up. Your child acts out the other side.

TALK

"If I'm tall, you're...?"



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 28

AGES 3-5 MEDIUM

MOVE

Tape Balance Beam

YOU NEED

Painter's tape, a soft toy

TRY IT

Put a tape line on the floor. Walk it forward, backward, on tiptoes, with a toy on your head.

TALK

"Can you walk it like a crab?"

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

3-5 · 29

AGES 3-5 CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Color Mixing

YOU NEED

Washable paint, paper, a brush

TRY IT

Mix two colors and see what appears. Paint a rainbow with your new colors.

TALK

"What happens if we add yellow?"



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 30

AGES 3-5 WIGGLY

GAMES & PUZZLES

Red Light, Green Light

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

"Green light" means move, "red light" means freeze, "yellow light" means slow motion. Swap callers.

TALK

"What other lights could we invent?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 31

AGES 3-5 CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Make a Little Book

YOU NEED

3 sheets of paper folded in half, crayons

TRY IT

Fold a little book. Your child draws a picture on each page; you write down their words.

TALK

"What happens on this page?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 32

AGES 3-5 WIGGLY

PRETEND

Rescue Mission

YOU NEED

Soft toys, a blanket

TRY IT

Toys are stuck on the couch "island." Your child rescues each one and brings it to safe base.

TALK

"Who needs help? How will you get there?"



Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 33

AGES 3-5 CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Snack Patterns

YOU NEED

Crackers, cheese cubes, banana slices

TRY IT

Make a pattern on a plate: cracker, cheese, cracker, cheese. What comes next? Then eat it.

TALK

"How did you know what comes next?"

Sit to eat; check allergies.

3-5 · 34

AGES 3-5 MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Sock Ball Toss

YOU NEED

Rolled-up socks, a laundry basket

TRY IT

Toss sock balls into the basket. Take a step back after every goal. Keep score with tally marks.

TALK

"How many went in? What helped?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 35

AGES 3-5 CALM

MOVE

Animal Stretches

YOU NEED

A rug or towel

TRY IT

Stretch like a cat, stand like a flamingo, curl up like a mouse. Breathe slowly between each.

TALK

"Which animal feels the calmest?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 36

AGES 3-5

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Flashlight Stories

YOU NEED

A flashlight, a dim room

TRY IT

Make hand shadows on the wall and tell a short story with them.

TALK

"What does the shadow bird want?"

Grown-up nearby.

3-5 · 37

AGES 3-5

MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Build a Nest

YOU NEED

Sticks, leaves, grass, a soft toy

TRY IT

Gather sticks and leaves outside. Build a nest big enough for a soft-toy bird.

TALK

"What would a bird need in its nest?"

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street.

3-5 · 38

AGES 3-5

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card play.

AGES 3-5

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card play.

AGES 3-5

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card play.

AGES 3-5

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card play.

AGES 3-5

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card play.

AGES 3-5

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card play.

AGES 3-5

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card play.

AGES 5-8 MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Cardboard City

YOU NEED

Boxes, tape, markers

TRY IT

Turn boxes into buildings. Add roads, a park and signs. Give your city a name.

TALK

"Who lives here? What job do they do?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 01

AGES 5-8 MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Paper Plane Contest

YOU NEED

Paper

TRY IT

Fold three different planes. Test each one three times. Which flies farthest? Which loops?

TALK

"What change made it fly farther?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 02

AGES 5-8 WIGGLY

MOVE

Backyard Games Day

YOU NEED

Chalk, paper for medals

TRY IT

Invent 4 events: hop race, sock-ball throw, silly walk, balance. Make paper medals.

TALK

"Which event was hardest? Why?"

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street. 5-8 · 03

AGES 5-8 CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Invent a Board Game

YOU NEED

Paper, markers, a die

TRY IT

Draw a path of 30 squares. Add "go back 2" and "extra turn" squares. Play it!

TALK

"What rule would make it fairer?"

Keep small pieces away from children under 3. 5-8 · 04

AGES 5-8 CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Four-Box Comic

YOU NEED

Paper folded into 4 boxes, pencils

TRY IT

Draw a four-box comic: a character, a problem, a try, a surprise ending.

TALK

"What does your character want?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 05

AGES 5-8 CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Kitchen Fizz

YOU NEED

Baking soda, vinegar, cups, a tray

TRY IT

Spoon baking soda into a cup on a tray. Add vinegar a little at a time. Try more, try less.

TALK

"What do you notice? Why does it fizz?"

Grown-up helps pour. Don't taste; keep faces back. 5-8 · 06

AGES 5-8 MEDIUM

PRETEND

Restaurant Night

YOU NEED

Paper, pencils, plates, a real snack

TRY IT

Your child writes a menu, takes orders, serves the snack and brings the bill.

TALK

"What's today's special? How much?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 07

AGES 5-8 MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Chalk Maze

YOU NEED

Sidewalk chalk

TRY IT

Draw a giant maze on the pavement. Others try to walk it without stepping on a line.

TALK

"Where is the trick in your maze?"

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street. 5-8 · 08

AGES 5-8 CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Would You Rather?

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Take turns: "Would you rather fly or be invisible?" Always add "because..."

TALK

"Why? Tell me more."

Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 09

AGES 5-8

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Cup Tower Challenge

YOU NEED

20 or more paper or plastic cups

TRY IT

Build the tallest tower you can in 2 minutes. Then the widest. Then one with a door.

TALK

"What worked best at the bottom?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 10

AGES 5-8

CALM

OUTDOORS

Nature Journal

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil, a book to lean on

TRY IT

Sit outside for 10 minutes. Draw one leaf, one bug and one cloud. Label what you see.

TALK

"What did you notice for the first time?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 11

AGES 5-8

CALM

OUTDOORS

Shadow Tracing

YOU NEED

Chalk, a sunny day, a few toys

TRY IT

Stand toys in the sun and trace their shadows. Come back in an hour: did they move?

TALK

"Why did the shadow move?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 12

AGES 5-8

WIGGLY

MUSIC & SOUND

Dance Party DJ

YOU NEED

Songs you can sing

TRY IT

Your child picks the songs and a dance move for each. Everyone copies the DJ.

TALK

"Which move goes with which song?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 13

AGES 5-8

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Secret Code

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil

TRY IT

Make a code: A = 1, B = 2... Write a secret message. Swap and crack each other's.

TALK

"How did you figure it out?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 14

AGES 5-8

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Fort Library

YOU NEED

Blankets, books, a flashlight

TRY IT

Build a fort and turn it into a library. Make library cards, "check out" books and read inside.

TALK

"Which book would you recommend to me?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 15

AGES 5-8

WIGGLY

MOVE

Sock-Ball Hoops

YOU NEED

Rolled socks, a laundry basket

TRY IT

Put the basket on a chair. Shoot from 1, 2 and 3 steps away. Keep score.

TALK

"What's your best trick shot?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 16

AGES 5-8

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Foil Boat Challenge

YOU NEED

Foil, a tub of water, coins

TRY IT

Shape a boat from foil. Float it and add coins one at a time. How many before it sinks?

TALK

"What shape held the most?"

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Coins away from under-3s.

5-8 · 17

AGES 5-8

MEDIUM

MUSIC & SOUND

Talent Show

YOU NEED

A rug for a stage, paper

TRY IT

Plan a show: a song, a joke, a trick. Make tickets and introduce every act.

TALK

"What's your act called?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often.

5-8 · 18

AGES 5-8  CALM

WORDS & STORIES

One-Word Story



YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Tell a story one word at a time, taking turns. See how silly it gets. Then try a sentence each.

TALK

"What should happen next?"



Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 19

AGES 5-8  CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Measure with Shoes



YOU NEED

A shoe, paper, pencil

TRY IT

Guess how many shoes long the couch is. Measure and compare. Try the table and your grown-up.

TALK

"Was your guess close? Why?"

Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 20

AGES 5-8  MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Lunch Makers



YOU NEED

Bread, spread, a butter knife, fruit

TRY IT

Your child makes lunch for the family: spread, cut into shapes, put it on plates.

TALK

"What order do the steps go in?"

Butter knife only; grown-up cuts fruit. Check allergies. 5-8 · 21

AGES 5-8  MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Hallway Bowling



YOU NEED

6 empty plastic bottles, a soft ball

TRY IT

Set the bottles up like pins. Roll, count what falls and write down the scores.

TALK

"What helps you get a strike?"



Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 22

AGES 5-8  MEDIUM

WORDS & STORIES

Weather Reporter



YOU NEED

Paper, markers, a window

TRY IT

Look outside and give a weather report with a drawn map and a forecast for tomorrow.

TALK

"What should people wear tomorrow?"



Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 23

AGES 5-8  MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Box Theater



YOU NEED

A cereal box, markers, paper, straws

TRY IT

A grown-up cuts a window in the box. Decorate it, make paper puppets on straws and put on a show.

TALK

"Who's the hero? What goes wrong?"

Grown-up does the cutting. 5-8 · 24

AGES 5-8  CALM

OUTDOORS

Grow a Seed



YOU NEED

A pot, soil, a few seeds, water

TRY IT

Plant the seeds. Water them and check each day. Draw how they change.

TALK

"What do you think it needs to grow?"

Wash hands after soil. Seeds away from under-3s. 5-8 · 25

AGES 5-8  WIGGLY

GAMES & PUZZLES

Hide and Seek



YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Play classic hide and seek indoors. The seeker counts to 20 out loud.

TALK

"What makes a great hiding spot?"



Never hide in appliances, chests, trunks or cars. 5-8 · 26

AGES 5-8  CALM

MUSIC & SOUND

Rhythm Copycat



YOU NEED

Hands, a table

TRY IT

Clap or tap a rhythm. Your partner copies it. Make it one beat longer each time.

TALK

"Can you make one I can't copy?"



Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 27

AGES 5-8 

WORDS & STORIES

Postcard to a Friend

YOU NEED

A piece of card, pencils

TRY IT

Draw a picture on one side. Write 3 sentences on the other. Mail it or hand-deliver it.

TALK

"What's your best news for them?"

 Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 28

AGES 5-8 

OUTDOORS

Rubbing Hunt

YOU NEED

Paper, crayons with the wrapper peeled

TRY IT

Put paper over a leaf and rub with the side of a crayon. Try bark, a doormat, a coin.

TALK

"Which texture made the coolest pattern?"

 Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 29

AGES 5-8 

MOVE

Yoga Story

YOU NEED

A rug

TRY IT

Tell a story with poses: a tree in the wind, a stretching cat, a mountain, a sleepy mouse.

TALK

"What happens when the wind stops?"

 Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 30

AGES 5-8 

PRETEND

Toy Store Math

YOU NEED

Toys, sticky notes, coins or paper money

TRY IT

Price toys from 1¢ to 20¢. Take turns buying and making change.

TALK

"Do you have enough? What's left?"

 Coins away from children under 3. 5-8 · 31

AGES 5-8 

BUILD & MAKE

Ramp Races

YOU NEED

Cardboard, books, toy cars

TRY IT

Build ramps at different heights. Race cars down and measure how far each one rolls.

TALK

"Why did that one go farther?"

 Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 32

AGES 5-8 

OUTDOORS

Sharks and Minnows

YOU NEED

A yard or park, 3 or more players

TRY IT

The shark stands in the middle; minnows run across. Tagged minnows become seaweed that tags from one spot.

TALK

"What's your plan to get across?"

 Grassy space, away from the street. 5-8 · 33

AGES 5-8 

KITCHEN & HELPING

Tidy-Up Detective

YOU NEED

A basket

TRY IT

A grown-up describes something out of place: "I spy something red with wheels." Find it, put it away.

TALK

"Give me a clue for the next one."

 Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 34

AGES 5-8 

GAMES & PUZZLES

Shape Pictures

YOU NEED

Cardboard, child-safe scissors

TRY IT

Cut squares, triangles and circles. Build a house, a cat, a rocket. Challenge each other.

TALK

"How many triangles did you use?"

 Child-safe scissors; grown-up nearby. 5-8 · 35

AGES 5-8 

WORDS & STORIES

Interview a Grown-Up

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil

TRY IT

Ask a grown-up: "What was your favorite game as a kid?" Write or draw the answers.

TALK

"What surprised you most?"

 Grown-up nearby; check in often. 5-8 · 36

AGES 5-8

CALM

MUSIC & SOUND

Jar Xylophone

YOU NEED

5 glass jars, water, a metal spoon

TRY IT

Fill jars with different amounts of water. Tap gently and line them up from low to high.

TALK

"Why does more water sound lower?"

Grown-up handles the glass; tap gently.

5-8 • 37

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 5-8

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Cook from a Recipe

YOU NEED

A simple recipe and its ingredients

TRY IT

Your child reads the recipe, gathers everything and cooks with you: pancakes, pasta salad, smoothies.

TALK

“What step was trickiest?”

Grown-up at the stove and with sharp knives.

8–12 · 01

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Chain Reaction

YOU NEED

Dominoes, books, cups, tubes, a toy car

TRY IT

Build a machine where each thing knocks the next. Make it end by tipping a cup.

TALK

“Where did it break? How did you fix it?”

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

8–12 · 02

AGES 8–12

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Write a Mystery

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil

TRY IT

Invent a mystery with 3 suspects and 3 clues. Hide the clues; the family solves it.

TALK

“Which clue gives it away?”

Grown-up at home; check in often.

8–12 · 03

AGES 8–12

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Learn a Card Game

YOU NEED

A deck of cards

TRY IT

Learn a new card game from a grown-up, like Rummy or Crazy Eights. Then teach it to someone else.

TALK

“What’s the best strategy?”

Grown-up at home; check in often.

8–12 · 04

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Backyard Camp

YOU NEED

A tent or blankets, a flashlight, snacks

TRY IT

Set up camp in the yard or living room. Plan dinner, stories and star-spotting.

TALK

“What do we need for our camp?”

No fires. Grown-up nearby after dark.

8–12 · 05

AGES 8–12

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Dream Room Plan

YOU NEED

Graph paper, a ruler, a pencil

TRY IT

Measure your room and draw it to scale. Then redesign it and add one secret feature.

TALK

“Why did you put that there?”

Grown-up at home; check in often.

8–12 · 06

AGES 8–12

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Flip Book

YOU NEED

A sticky-note pad, a pencil

TRY IT

Draw a stick figure on each page, moving it a little each time. Flip fast to watch it move.

TALK

“How many pages does a jump need?”

Grown-up at home; check in often.

8–12 · 07

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

WORDS & STORIES

Radio Show

YOU NEED

Paper for a script

TRY IT

Write and perform a 5-minute radio show: news, weather and an ad for a made-up product.

TALK

“What story leads your show?”

Grown-up at home; check in often.

8–12 · 08

AGES 8–12

WIGGLY

MOVE

Skills Challenge

YOU NEED

A ball, shoes as markers

TRY IT

Set up a dribble course, a target and a keep-up challenge. Write your best. Beat it tomorrow.

TALK

“What did you do on your best try?”

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street.

8–12 · 09

AGES 8–12

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Paper Bridge

YOU NEED

10 sheets of paper, tape, coins, 2 books

TRY IT

Build a bridge between two books 8 in (20 cm) apart using only paper and tape. How many coins can it hold?

TALK

“What shape made it strongest?”

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

8–12 · 10

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

MOVE

Learn to Juggle

YOU NEED

3 rolled-up socks

TRY IT

Toss one sock hand to hand. Add a second. Then try three. Count your record.

TALK

“What’s the trick to the rhythm?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 11

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

WORDS & STORIES

Family Newspaper

YOU NEED

Paper, pencils

TRY IT

Report the news from home: interviews, weather, sports, comics. Hand out copies.

TALK

“What’s today’s headline?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 12

AGES 8–12

CALM

OUTDOORS

Map the Block

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil, a walk

TRY IT

Walk around the block with a grown-up and draw a map. Add landmarks and a key.

TALK

“What would a visitor need to know?”

Walk with a grown-up; stay on the sidewalk. 8–12 · 13

AGES 8–12

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Card House

YOU NEED

An old deck of cards

TRY IT

Build the tallest card house you can. Try leaning triangles, then flat roofs.

TALK

“What made it fall? What steadied it?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 14

AGES 8–12

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Chess or Checkers

YOU NEED

A chess or checkers set

TRY IT

Play a game. Before each move, say your plan out loud.

TALK

“Why that move? What’s your plan?”

Keep small pieces away from children under 3. 8–12 · 15

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Egg Drop

YOU NEED

A raw egg, paper, tape, straws, a bag

TRY IT

Design a package that keeps an egg safe when a grown-up drops it from a chair. Test, fix, retest.

TALK

“What would you change for version two?”

Grown-up does the dropping. Wash hands after. 8–12 · 16

AGES 8–12

CALM

MUSIC & SOUND

New Words, Old Tune

YOU NEED

Paper, a tune you know

TRY IT

Write new words to a song you already know: about the dog, school or dinner. Perform it.

TALK

“What’s your funniest line?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 17

AGES 8–12

WIGGLY

MOVE

Card Workout

YOU NEED

A deck of cards

TRY IT

Give each suit a move (hearts = jumping jacks, spades = squats). Flip a card; do that many.

TALK

“Which suit was toughest?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 18

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

WORDS & STORIES

Silly Debate

YOU NEED

A silly topic

TRY IT

Pick a topic ("Is cereal soup?"). Each side argues for 1 minute. Then swap sides.

TALK

"What was the other side's best point?"



Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 19

AGES 8–12

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Origami

YOU NEED

Square paper, a library book

TRY IT

Learn to fold a crane, a frog or a fortune teller. Then teach someone else.

TALK

"Which fold was hardest to explain?"



Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 20

AGES 8–12

CALM

OUTDOORS

Bird Count

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil, a window or yard

TRY IT

Sit still for 15 minutes. Tally every bird you see and sketch the most common one.

TALK

"Which birds came back? Why there?"



Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 21

AGES 8–12

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Party on a Budget

YOU NEED

Paper, a pretend \$50

TRY IT

Plan a pretend party for \$50: food, games, decorations. Add it all up.

TALK

"What would you cut if it went over?"



Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 22

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Home Escape Room

YOU NEED

Paper, a box, 3 puzzles

TRY IT

Design 3 puzzles. Each answer gives one number of a code that "unlocks" the box.

TALK

"Which puzzle stumped us longest?"

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 23

AGES 8–12

WIGGLY

MOVE

Invent a Sport

YOU NEED

A ball, things in the yard

TRY IT

Invent a sport with 3 rules and a way to score. Teach it and play. Then change one rule.

TALK

"Which rule made it more fun?"

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street. 8–12 · 24

AGES 8–12

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Letter to Future You

YOU NEED

Paper, an envelope

TRY IT

Write a letter to open in one year: favorites, friends, hopes. Seal it and date it.

TALK

"What do you think will change?"



Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 25

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Bake and Share

YOU NEED

A muffin or bread recipe

TRY IT

Bake together and deliver some to a neighbor or friend.

TALK

"Who would love a surprise?"



Grown-up at the oven. Check allergies. 8–12 · 26

AGES 8–12

CALM

OUTDOORS

Stargazing

YOU NEED

A clear night, a blanket

TRY IT

Lie on a blanket. Find the Moon's shape, a bright planet, a star pattern. Draw what you see.

TALK

"What shapes can you invent in the stars?"



Grown-up with you after dark. 8–12 · 27

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Cardboard Arcade

YOU NEED

Boxes, tape, markers, a soft ball

TRY IT

Build arcade games from boxes: a ball toss, a ramp, a target. Make tickets and prizes.

TALK

“How does the scoring work?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 28

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

PRETEND

Magic Trick

YOU NEED

A deck of cards or a coin

TRY IT

Learn one magic trick from a library book. Practice 10 times, then perform it.

TALK

“How do you keep the secret?”

Keep small pieces away from children under 3. 8–12 · 29

AGES 8–12

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Speed Sketch

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil, a clock

TRY IT

Draw the same object in 5 minutes, then 1 minute, then 10 seconds. Compare.

TALK

“What did you keep when time was short?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 30

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Family Trivia

YOU NEED

Paper, pencil

TRY IT

Your child writes 10 trivia questions about the family and hosts a quiz show.

TALK

“Which question fooled everyone?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 31

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Plant a Garden

YOU NEED

Soil, seeds, a trowel, water

TRY IT

Pick what to grow, sketch the rows, plant and label them. Water and check each week.

TALK

“What will you do if it doesn’t sprout?”

Gloves for soil; wash hands after. 8–12 · 32

AGES 8–12

CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Flashlight Code

YOU NEED

2 flashlights

TRY IT

Make a code of short and long flashes. Send messages across a dark room or yard.

TALK

“What’s the shortest message that works?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 33

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Fix It Together

YOU NEED

Something loose or wobbly, basic tools

TRY IT

Tighten a loose screw, steady a wobbly chair or mend a toy with a grown-up.

TALK

“How did you figure out what was wrong?”

Grown-up handles sharp and power tools. 8–12 · 34

AGES 8–12

WIGGLY

MUSIC & SOUND

Bucket Drums

YOU NEED

An upturned bucket, 2 wooden spoons

TRY IT

Hit the middle for a low beat and the edge for a snap. Build a 4-beat pattern and play along to a song.

TALK

“Can you teach me your pattern?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 35

AGES 8–12

MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Pass-It-On Shop

YOU NEED

A box

TRY IT

Sort outgrown toys and books. Choose what to pass on, and set up a “shop” for friends or donation.

TALK

“What’s hard to give away? Why?”

Grown-up at home; check in often. 8–12 · 36

AGES 8-12

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Twenty Questions

YOU NEED

Nothing

TRY IT

Think of a person, place or thing. Others ask up to 20 yes-or-no questions to guess it.

TALK

“Which question helped the most?”

8-12 · 37

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 8-12

CALM

MED

WIGGLY

YOUR IDEA

YOU NEED

TRY IT

TALK

Check the safety page before you play.

Your card

AGES 3-8
WIGGLY

MOVE

Sprinkler Course

YOU NEED
A sprinkler, a towel, chalk

TRY IT
Make a course: run through the sprinkler, hop chalk circles, crawl under a towel bridge.

TALK
“Which part is the splashiest?”

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Watch slippery grass.
 Summer · 01

AGES 3-8
CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Ice Rescue

YOU NEED
Big toys frozen in a tub of ice, warm water, spoons

TRY IT
Freeze big toys in a tub overnight. Rescue them with warm water and spoons.

TALK
“What melts fastest? Why?”

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.
 Summer · 02

AGES 3-12
CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Chalk Gallery

YOU NEED
Sidewalk chalk

TRY IT
Draw a gallery of pictures on the pavement. Title each one and hold a gallery walk.

TALK
“Tell me about this one.”

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street.
 Summer · 03

AGES 1-12
CALM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Backyard Picnic

YOU NEED
A blanket, snacks

TRY IT
Plan and pack a picnic together. Eat outside, then play I Spy.

TALK
“What should we pack? Who's coming?”

Sit to eat. For little ones: no whole grapes, nuts or popcorn.
 Summer · 04

AGES 1-5
MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Toy Car Wash

YOU NEED
A bucket of soapy water, sponges, big plastic toys

TRY IT
Set up a car wash for ride-ons and big plastic toys. Scrub, rinse and dry.

TALK
“Which one is the dirtiest?”

Water: grown-up within arm's reach. Toys bigger than a toilet-paper tube.
 Summer · 05

AGES 5-12
MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Bug Hotel

YOU NEED
Sticks, bark, leaves, an old box

TRY IT
Fill a box with sticks, bark and leaves. Set it in a quiet corner and check who moves in.

TALK
“Which bug would like this room?”

Look, don't touch. Wash hands after.
 Summer · 06

AGES 5-12
WIGGLY

MOVE

Shadow Tag

YOU NEED
A sunny day

TRY IT
Try to step on each other's shadows. If yours gets stepped on, you're it.

TALK
“Where can you hide your shadow?”

Hat, water and shade breaks.
 Summer · 07

AGES 3-8
CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Nature Crowns

YOU NEED
A paper strip, tape, fallen leaves and petals

TRY IT
Make a paper crown. Tape on leaves and petals from the ground. Hold a garden parade.

TALK
“What is your crown made of?”

Grown-up checks plants. Nothing in mouths.
 Summer · 08

AGES 5-12
CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Silly Camp Stories

YOU NEED
A flashlight, a blanket

TRY IT
Take turns telling a story in the dusk with a flashlight. Keep it funny, not scary.

TALK
“What's the twist?”

Grown-up with you after dark.
 Summer · 09

AGES 3–12

MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Ice-Pop Kitchen

YOU NEED
Juice, soft fruit, ice-pop molds or cups

TRY IT
Mix juice and fruit to invent a flavor. Name it, freeze it and taste-test tomorrow.

TALK
“What will you call your flavor?”

Check allergies. Grown-up does any cutting.

Summer · 10

AGES 5–12

CALM

BUILD & MAKE

Rock Painting

YOU NEED
Fist-size rocks, washable paint

TRY IT
Paint rocks with faces, patterns or kind words. Hide them in the garden for someone to find.

TALK
“Who will find this one?”

Paint and rocks away from children under 3.

Summer · 11

AGES 1–8

MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Sand Castle

YOU NEED
Sand, buckets, big spoons

TRY IT
Build a castle with a moat. Add big-leaf flags and pour water into the moat.

TALK
“Who lives in the castle?”

Water: grown-up within arm's reach. Keep sand out of mouths.

Summer · 12

AGES 3–8

MEDIUM

OUTDOORS

Nature Bingo

YOU NEED
A 3 × 3 grid on paper, a pencil

TRY IT
Draw 9 things you might see: a bird, a cloud, a red flower... Cross them off on a walk.

TALK
“What's still missing?”

Hat, water and shade breaks.

Summer · 13

AGES 5–12

WIGGLY

MOVE

Sponge Relay

YOU NEED
2 buckets, sponges, water

TRY IT
Carry water in a sponge from one bucket to the other. First to reach the line wins.

TALK
“What's the fastest way to carry it?”

Water play: grown-up within arm's reach the whole time.

Summer · 14

AGES 5–12

MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Plate Disc Golf

YOU NEED
Paper plates, 5 targets

TRY IT
Pick 5 targets as “holes.” Count your throws to hit each. Lowest score wins.

TALK
“Which hole was hardest?”

Play in the yard or park, well away from the street.

Summer · 15

AGES 3–12

CALM

OUTDOORS

Cloud Stories

YOU NEED
A blanket

TRY IT
Lie on your backs and find shapes in the clouds. Make up a story about one.

TALK
“What do you see? What's it doing?”

Hat, water and shade breaks.

Summer · 16

AGES 5–12

MEDIUM

PRETEND

Lemonade Stand

YOU NEED
Lemonade, cups, a sign

TRY IT
Plan a stand: sign, price, cups. Count the money and make change.

TALK
“What price is fair? Why?”

Grown-up with you the whole time.

Summer · 17

AGES 5–12

CALM

WORDS & STORIES

Summer Journal

YOU NEED
A notebook, pencils

TRY IT
Each day, draw one thing you did and write one sentence. Read it back at summer's end.

TALK
“What was the best day this week?”

Grown-up nearby.

Summer · 18

AGES 3–12
 CALM

PRETEND

Living-Room Camp

YOU NEED
Blankets, a flashlight, pillows

TRY IT
Pitch a blanket tent. Tell stories and “toast” paper pretend treats over a paper campfire.

TALK
 “What sounds do we hear at camp?”

Grown-up nearby.

Rainy · 01

AGES 1–8
 WIGGLY

OUTDOORS

Puddle Jumping

YOU NEED
Rain boots, a raincoat

TRY IT
Head out in gentle rain and jump in puddles. Find the biggest splash.

TALK
 “Big splash or little splash?”

Grown-up within reach. No thunder or lightning; hold hands near roads.

Rainy · 02

AGES 3–8
 CALM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Raindrop Race

YOU NEED
A rainy window

TRY IT
Each pick a raindrop at the top of the window. Cheer them down. Whose wins?

TALK
 “Why did yours speed up?”

Grown-up nearby.

Rainy · 03

AGES 3–12
 WIGGLY

MOVE

Sock Skating

YOU NEED
Socks, a smooth floor

TRY IT
Glide, spin and stop on a smooth floor in socks. Go slowly near furniture.

TALK
 “What’s your best move called?”

Clear the floor. No stairs.

Rainy · 04

AGES 3–8
 MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Blanket Maze

YOU NEED
Blankets, chairs, pillows

TRY IT
Make a maze of tunnels through the room, with dead ends and a secret exit.

TALK
 “Which way do we turn?”

Drape blankets loose; never tie them.

Rainy · 05

AGES 1–5
 CALM

MUSIC & SOUND

Rain Band

YOU NEED
Pots, pans, a plastic tub

TRY IT
Listen to the rain, then copy it: pitter-patter fingers, big drops on pots, thunder drums.

TALK
 “Is the rain soft or loud now?”

Grown-up within reach. Big pots and tubs only.

Rainy · 06

AGES 5–8
 MEDIUM

BUILD & MAKE

Paper Boats

YOU NEED
Paper, a tub of water, a straw

TRY IT
Fold paper boats. Float them in the tub and blow them across with a straw.

TALK
 “How long did yours float?”

Water play: grown-up within arm’s reach the whole time.

Rainy · 07

AGES 5–12
 MEDIUM

KITCHEN & HELPING

Rainy-Day Soup

YOU NEED
Vegetables, broth, a pot

TRY IT
Wash, count and add the vegetables with a grown-up. Taste and name your soup.

TALK
 “What should we add next?”

Grown-up at the stove and with sharp knives.

Rainy · 08

AGES 5–8
 MEDIUM

GAMES & PUZZLES

Treasure Map

YOU NEED
Paper, pencil, a small treasure

TRY IT
Draw a map of your home with an X. Hide the treasure. Swap maps and find it.

TALK
 “Which clue helped most?”

Keep small pieces away from children under 3.

Rainy · 09

AGES 3–8

BUILD & MAKE

Weather Art

YOU NEED
Paper, crayons or washable paint

TRY IT
Draw what rain looks like, sounds like and feels like, with lots of lines and dots.

TALK
“What color is rain?”

Grown-up nearby.
 Rainy · 10

AGES 1–12

WORDS & STORIES

Reading Nest

YOU NEED
Pillows, blankets, a pile of books

TRY IT
Make a cozy nest by the window. Take turns choosing a book and read it with voices.

TALK
“Which character would you be?”

Grown-up within reach of little ones.
 Rainy · 11

AGES 5–12

OUTDOORS

Rain Gauge

YOU NEED
A clear jar, a ruler, a marker

TRY IT
Set the jar outside. Mark the water level every hour. Draw a graph of the rain.

TALK
“When did it rain hardest?”

Grown-up handles the jar.
 Rainy · 12

AGES 3–8

GAMES & PUZZLES

Warmer, Colder

YOU NEED
A toy to hide

TRY IT
One person hides the toy. The other searches while you say “warmer” or “colder.”

TALK
“Warmer... hotter... you’ve got it!”

Grown-up nearby.
 Rainy · 13

AGES 3–8

MOVE

Storm Stretch

YOU NEED
A rug

TRY IT
Act out a storm: rain fingers, wind arms, thunder stomps. End with a slow sunshine stretch.

TALK
“How does your body feel now?”

Grown-up nearby.
 Rainy · 14

AGES 5–12

GAMES & PUZZLES

Card Game Marathon

YOU NEED
A deck of cards

TRY IT
Play Go Fish, then War, then Memory. Keep a tally of who wins each game.

TALK
“Which game needs a rematch?”

Grown-up nearby.
 Rainy · 15

AGES 3–8

PRETEND

Fashion Show

YOU NEED
Grown-up clothes, hats

TRY IT
Put on a runway show with silly outfits. Announce each look like a host.

TALK
“Tell us about this outfit!”

Skip ties, belts and long scarves around necks.
 Rainy · 16

AGES 5–8

KITCHEN & HELPING

Cloud in a Jar

YOU NEED
A jar of water, shaving foam, colored water

TRY IT
Top the water with a foam “cloud.” Drip colored water on top until it “rains.”

TALK
“When does the cloud get too full?”

Grown-up handles the foam. Don’t taste.
 Rainy · 17

AGES 5–8

BUILD & MAKE

Paper Doll Chain

YOU NEED
Paper, child-safe scissors, crayons

TRY IT
Fold paper like a fan, draw a person, cut and unfold. Decorate each one as someone you love.

TALK
“Who is this one?”

Child-safe scissors; grown-up nearby.
 Rainy · 18

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 1-3

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 3-5

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS · AGES 5-8

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • AGES 8-12

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels

**I'm
bored!**

PLAY CARDS • SUMMER SET

Play Before Pixels



AGES 1–3

1–3

Ages 1–3

38 play cards

AGES 3–5

3–5

Ages 3–5

38 play cards

AGES 5–8

5–8

Ages 5–8

37 play cards

AGES 8–12

8–12

Ages 8–12

37 play cards

BUILD



Build & Make

Kind of play

PRETEND



Pretend

Kind of play

MOVE



Move

Kind of play

OUTDOORS



Outdoors

Kind of play

WORDS



Words & Stories

Kind of play

MUSIC



Music & Sound

Kind of play

HELPING



**Kitchen &
Helping**

Kind of play

GAMES



**Games &
Puzzles**

Kind of play

SUMMER



Summer

18 cards

RAINY DAY



Rainy day

18 cards

FAVORITES



Family favorites

The ones we play again and again

TRIED IT



Tried it!

Played at least once

SAVE FOR LATER



Save for later

Not today, maybe next time

OUR IDEAS



Our own ideas

Cards we made up ourselves

Round jar labels

Four colorways. Cut on the dashed circle and stick to the jar with clear tape or glue dots.

Label size: 3.4 in / 8.6 cm.



Wrap labels & energy jars

Use one big jar, or split the cards into three energy jars so your child can choose the mood first.

I'm bored!

PLAY CARDS FOR OUR FAMILY

 Pull a card · Play together · Talk about it



I'm bored!

SCREEN-FREE PLAY IDEAS

 Pull a card · Play together · Talk about it



 CALM

Calm jar

Quiet, sit-down play

 MEDIUM

Medium jar

Up-and-about play

 WIGGLY

Wiggly jar

Big-body play

 LOVED

Done & loved

Cards we loved go here

Today's Play Menu

Velcro one card into each space, then let your child choose. Done? Move it to the "Done & loved" jar.

Calm pick



CARD GOES HERE

Wiggly pick



CARD GOES HERE

Together pick



CARD GOES HERE

Free choice



CARD GOES HERE

Our Play Week

WEEK OF

PLAYER(S)

DAY	CARD WE PLAYED	ENERGY C · M · W	SOMETHING THEY SAID	LOVED IT?
Monday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Tuesday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Wednesday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Thursday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Friday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Saturday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Sunday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★

Why write it down?

The funny things children say while they play are easy to forget. A line a day becomes a little record of your year, and a reminder of which cards to play again.

Our Play Week

WEEK OF _____

PLAYER(S) _____

DAY	CARD WE PLAYED	ENERGY C • M • W	SOMETHING THEY SAID	LOVED IT?
Sunday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Monday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Tuesday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Wednesday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Thursday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Friday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★
Saturday		○ ○ ○		★ ★ ★

Why write it down?

The funny things children say while they play are easy to forget. A line a day becomes a little record of your year, and a reminder of which cards to play again.



OFFICIAL

Play Jar Star

This certificate goes to

for playing ☐ 10 ☐ 25 ☐ 50 ☐ 100 cards from the "I'm bored!" jar.

FAVORITE CARD

DATE

OUR TOP THREE CARDS

- 1 _____
- 2 _____
- 3 _____



BEST THING WE SAID WHILE WE
PLAYED

Tick a box when you've played a card. = kind of play · bars = energy

Ages 1-3

38 CARDS

☐	01	Pot-and-Spoon Band		
☐	02	Box Car Ride		
☐	03	Peekaboo Towel		
☐	04	Tower and Crash		
☐	05	Roll It Back		
☐	06	Sink Helper		
☐	07	Sock Match		
☐	08	Animal Parade		
☐	09	Mirror Faces		
☐	10	Basket Boat		
☐	11	Treasure Box		
☐	12	Pillow Mountain		
☐	13	Bubble Chase		
☐	14	Sock Puppet Hello		
☐	15	Color Hunt		
☐	16	Stop-and-Go Dance		
☐	17	Picture Walk		
☐	18	Cups and Bowls		
☐	19	Paint with Water		
☐	20	Teddy Picnic		
☐	21	Sheet Tunnel		
☐	22	Wipe the Table		
☐	23	Nature Basket		
☐	24	Car Ramp		
☐	25	Pretend Phone Call		
☐	26	Big Paper Scribble		
☐	27	Pillow Hop		
☐	28	Fill-In Songs		
☐	29	What's That Sound?		
☐	30	Point-and-Name Walk		
☐	31	Lid Match		
☐	32	Teddy Bedtime		
☐	33	Delivery Push		
☐	34	Where's Teddy?		
☐	35	Tidy-Up Toss		
☐	36	Hand Shadows		
☐	37	Knee Bounce Ride		
☐	38	Fill and Dump		

Ages 3-5

38 CARDS

☐	01	Cushion Fort		
☐	02	The Floor Is Lava		
☐	03	Pretend Café		
☐	04	Laundry Sort		
☐	05	Picture-Clue Hunt		
☐	06	Tape Road		
☐	07	Simon Says		
☐	08	Feel-It Hunt		
☐	09	Story in a Bag		
☐	10	Dough Bakery		
☐	11	Animal Charades		
☐	12	Rhyme Basket		
☐	13	Veggie Scrub		
☐	14	Obstacle Course		
☐	15	Toy Vet		
☐	16	Sink or Float		
☐	17	Feelings Freeze		
☐	18	Book Bridge		
☐	19	I Spy Colors		
☐	20	Paper-Plate Masks		
☐	21	Chalk Hop Path		
☐	22	Couch Puppet Show		
☐	23	Corner Shop		
☐	24	Mail Carrier		
☐	25	Bug Watch		
☐	26	Kitchen Band		
☐	27	Listening Walk		
☐	28	Opposites Game		
☐	29	Tape Balance Beam		
☐	30	Color Mixing		
☐	31	Red Light, Green Light		
☐	32	Make a Little Book		
☐	33	Rescue Mission		
☐	34	Snack Patterns		
☐	35	Sock Ball Toss		
☐	36	Animal Stretches		
☐	37	Flashlight Stories		
☐	38	Build a Nest		

Tick a box when you've played a card. = kind of play · bars = energy

Ages 5–8

37 CARDS

- | | | |
|-----------------------------|----------------------|--|
| ☐ 01 | Cardboard City | |
| ☐ 02 | Paper Plane Contest | |
| ☐ 03 | Backyard Games Day | |
| ☐ 04 | Invent a Board Game | |
| ☐ 05 | Four-Box Comic | |
| ☐ 06 | Kitchen Fizz | |
| ☐ 07 | Restaurant Night | |
| ☐ 08 | Chalk Maze | |
| ☐ 09 | Would You Rather? | |
| ☐ 10 | Cup Tower Challenge | |
| ☐ 11 | Nature Journal | |
| ☐ 12 | Shadow Tracing | |
| ☐ 13 | Dance Party DJ | |
| ☐ 14 | Secret Code | |
| ☐ 15 | Fort Library | |
| ☐ 16 | Sock-Ball Hoops | |
| ☐ 17 | Foil Boat Challenge | |
| ☐ 18 | Talent Show | |
| ☐ 19 | One-Word Story | |
| ☐ 20 | Measure with Shoes | |
| ☐ 21 | Lunch Makers | |
| ☐ 22 | Hallway Bowling | |
| ☐ 23 | Weather Reporter | |
| ☐ 24 | Box Theater | |
| ☐ 25 | Grow a Seed | |
| ☐ 26 | Hide and Seek | |
| ☐ 27 | Rhythm Copycat | |
| ☐ 28 | Postcard to a Friend | |
| ☐ 29 | Rubbing Hunt | |
| ☐ 30 | Yoga Story | |
| ☐ 31 | Toy Store Math | |
| ☐ 32 | Ramp Races | |
| ☐ 33 | Sharks and Minnows | |
| ☐ 34 | Tidy-Up Detective | |
| ☐ 35 | Shape Pictures | |
| ☐ 36 | Interview a Grown-Up | |
| ☐ 37 | Jar Xylophone | |

Ages 8–12

37 CARDS

- | | | |
|-----------------------------|----------------------|--|
| ☐ 01 | Cook from a Recipe | |
| ☐ 02 | Chain Reaction | |
| ☐ 03 | Write a Mystery | |
| ☐ 04 | Learn a Card Game | |
| ☐ 05 | Backyard Camp | |
| ☐ 06 | Dream Room Plan | |
| ☐ 07 | Flip Book | |
| ☐ 08 | Radio Show | |
| ☐ 09 | Skills Challenge | |
| ☐ 10 | Paper Bridge | |
| ☐ 11 | Learn to Juggle | |
| ☐ 12 | Family Newspaper | |
| ☐ 13 | Map the Block | |
| ☐ 14 | Card House | |
| ☐ 15 | Chess or Checkers | |
| ☐ 16 | Egg Drop | |
| ☐ 17 | New Words, Old Tune | |
| ☐ 18 | Card Workout | |
| ☐ 19 | Silly Debate | |
| ☐ 20 | Origami | |
| ☐ 21 | Bird Count | |
| ☐ 22 | Party on a Budget | |
| ☐ 23 | Home Escape Room | |
| ☐ 24 | Invent a Sport | |
| ☐ 25 | Letter to Future You | |
| ☐ 26 | Bake and Share | |
| ☐ 27 | Stargazing | |
| ☐ 28 | Cardboard Arcade | |
| ☐ 29 | Magic Trick | |
| ☐ 30 | Speed Sketch | |
| ☐ 31 | Family Trivia | |
| ☐ 32 | Plant a Garden | |
| ☐ 33 | Flashlight Code | |
| ☐ 34 | Fix It Together | |
| ☐ 35 | Bucket Drums | |
| ☐ 36 | Pass-It-On Shop | |
| ☐ 37 | Twenty Questions | |

Tick a box when you've played a card. = kind of play · bars = energy

Summer set			18 CARDS
☐	01	Sprinkler Course	
☐	02	Ice Rescue	
☐	03	Chalk Gallery	
☐	04	Backyard Picnic	
☐	05	Toy Car Wash	
☐	06	Bug Hotel	
☐	07	Shadow Tag	
☐	08	Nature Crowns	
☐	09	Silly Camp Stories	
☐	10	Ice-Pop Kitchen	
☐	11	Rock Painting	
☐	12	Sand Castle	
☐	13	Nature Bingo	
☐	14	Sponge Relay	
☐	15	Plate Disc Golf	
☐	16	Cloud Stories	
☐	17	Lemonade Stand	
☐	18	Summer Journal	

Rainy-day set			18 CARDS
☐	01	Living-Room Camp	
☐	02	Puddle Jumping	
☐	03	Raindrop Race	
☐	04	Sock Skating	
☐	05	Blanket Maze	
☐	06	Rain Band	
☐	07	Paper Boats	
☐	08	Rainy-Day Soup	
☐	09	Treasure Map	
☐	10	Weather Art	
☐	11	Reading Nest	
☐	12	Rain Gauge	
☐	13	Warmer, Colder	
☐	14	Storm Stretch	
☐	15	Card Game Marathon	
☐	16	Fashion Show	
☐	17	Cloud in a Jar	
☐	18	Paper Doll Chain	

Blank cards

Each age band ends with a few blank “your idea” cards, and the editable file has fillable blanks in every color. The best cards are often the ones your child invents. Write them down!

Questions, answered.

My child is between two age bands.

Use both. The bands overlap on purpose, and many cards work a year or two either side.

My child says no to every card.

Offer just two cards, or let them pull one without looking. A little boredom is fine too: it often turns into their own idea.

Do I have to play too?

For ages 1–3, yes: you are the best toy in the room. For older children, start together, then step back and be the audience.

Which pages should I print?

Only what you need. The page guide on the “Make them last” page lists every section.

Can I print it again?

Yes. Print as many copies as your own household needs, as often as you like.

Can I print at a print shop?

Yes, for your own family’s use. Choose cardstock and ask them to print at 100% (actual size).

Can I share it with my class, group or friends?

This file is licensed for one household. For groups or classrooms, ask about a license through the contact form at playbeforepixels.com.

Is there a screen version?

No, and that’s on purpose. The cards are paper so the play happens off-screen.

How do I type on the blank cards?

Open the editable file in a free PDF reader app that supports fill-in forms, click a box and type. Or use the PNG template set in a design app.

Where is my free bonus?

On the last page: scan the QR code or type the short link.

Download or file trouble? Answers to common download and printing questions are at playbeforepixels.com/help.

One more thing: a free bonus.



[playbeforepixels.com/bonus/
bored-play-cards](https://playbeforepixels.com/bonus/bored-play-cards)

Scan the code or type the link for this pack's free companion: a printable seasonal mini-set of play cards and a short "play at this age" email each month.

We only ask for your email and your child's birth month and year, never names. Unsubscribe any time.

MORE FROM PLAY BEFORE PIXELS

52 Play & Talk Cards

For ages 0–5: one simple play and one talk tip on every card.

Visual Routine Cards

Picture cards for mornings, bedtime and the moments in between.

100 Screen-Free Plays

Our activity book: 100 plays sorted by age, each with a talk line and a safety note.



Happy playing!

© 2026 AlphaPlay LLC. Play Before Pixels is a trade name of AlphaPlay LLC. All rights reserved.

This file is for use in your own home. You may print as many copies as your family needs. Please don't share, resell or post the file or its pages. For group, classroom or other licenses, write to us through the contact form at playbeforepixels.com.

These cards are ideas for supervised play at home. They are parent education, not medical, developmental or professional advice, and they don't replace the judgment of the grown-up in charge. Follow the safety page and every card's safety line, and skip anything that doesn't suit your child.

Play Before Pixels is an independent small business. No brands, products or organizations are named or endorsed in this pack.